



OceanSafe · Beach Safety

O'ahu

Before you get in the water

EVERY BEACH, EVERY TIME

- ☐ **Find a lifeguard tower and swim in front of a staffed one.**
- ☐ **Never swim alone.** Keep a buddy in sight.
- ☐ **Watch keiki within arm's reach.** Calm, shallow water still drowns.
- ☐ **Ask the lifeguard what the water is doing today,** or check conditions before you go.
- ☐ **Never turn your back to the ocean.** The big wave in a set comes without warning.
- ☐ **Caught in a current? Don't fight it.** Stay calm, float, swim across it toward the beach, and wave for help.

O'AHU — KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- ☐ **Winter (about October–April), the North Shore and west side get huge, dangerous surf.** If the surf is up, stay out and watch from the sand.
- ☐ **Sandy Beach and Makapu'u shorebreak land right on the sand** and hurt strong swimmers. Sit those out unless you really know shorebreak.
- ☐ **Many drownings near Waikīkī happen offshore and are medical, not the waves.** Don't swim alone and stay within your depth.
- ☐ **Deep channels sit right next to shallow reef (like Ala Moana).** Keep weak swimmers on the reef flat.
- ☐ **Resort lagoons (Ko Olina) usually have no lifeguard.** Calm water still drowns young kids and older swimmers.
- ☐ **Give sea life room — harassing them is illegal.** Keep 10 ft from honu (turtles), 50 ft from monk seals.

● **Emergency: call 911, ask for Ocean Safety** When in doubt, don't go out.

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Maui

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MAUI — KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- ☐ **Snorkeling causes more visitor ocean deaths than anything else.** Snorkel close to shore, never alone, and get out if you feel cold, tired, or short of breath.
- ☐ **Calm-looking bays can pull hard.** Off Black Rock (Kā'anapali), Kapalua, and Nāpili, currents pick up when swell wraps in.
- ☐ **Winter north swells and summer south swells turn easy family beaches into dumping shorebreak.** Check conditions first.
- ☐ **Where there's a buoyed swim zone (Kānaha), stay inside it.** The water outside runs offshore.
- ☐ **Many West and South Maui beaches have no lifeguard.** Pick a guarded beach when you can, especially with kids.
- ☐ **Reef and rock are sharp and shallow.** Wear reef shoes and don't stand on the coral.

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OceanSafe · Beach Safety
Hawai'i Island
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HAWAI'I ISLAND — KNOW BEFORE YOU GO

- ☐ **More lava rock than sand.** Entries are sharp and uneven — wear reef shoes and pick calm days.
- ☐ **Many beaches are remote and unguarded** (Green Sand, Makalawena, Two Step). No lifeguard and weak or no cell signal — bring water and tell someone your plan.
- ☐ **Hilo/Keaukaha tidepools (Richardson, Onekahakaha, Carlsmith) look calm but have channels and currents.** Keep keiki close and in the protected pools.
- ☐ **Lava-entry snorkel spots like Two Step are for calm days only.** Get in and out at the steps, not over the reef.
- ☐ **Surf spots like Honoli'i are for experienced surfers,** not for swimming.
- ☐ **On any rocky shore, stay well back from wet rock.** A single sweeper wave can pull you in.

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